



ASSEMBLY
Elections 08

BJP, on the other hand, has adopted the Narendra Modi formula of going in for fresh faces to battle anti-incumbency and has dropped 18 of its 54 sitting MLAs.

The Congress is relatively free of the furious infighting that was witnessed early this year with the re-entry of party veteran and former Union minister V.C. Shukla. To take on Shukla, Jogi recently called a truce with AICC Treasurer Motilal Vora. Despite no major goof-ups in ticket distribution, surprisingly manageable levels of infighting and anti-incumbency weighing against the BJP, the Congress' task isn't any easier. Despite nearly three-and-a-half-years since the PCC was dissolved, a new executive body has not been formed till date. With the organisation in tatters, it is unable to build any momentum against the state Government.

Added to this is the Bahujan Samaj Party's (BSP) threat to the Congress' Dalit vote. Satnami tribals have been shifting towards the regional party ever since the late Kanshi Ram

THE BALLOT



**AJIT
JOGI**

The former chief minister will grab a large chunk of the tribal vote, but has not been able to build the party organisation.



**RAMAN
SINGH**

The chief minister has a clean image. His cheap rice scheme is a big hit but he still lacks a major issue to woo voters.

contested the Janjgir Lok Sabha seat in 1984. Jogi too has a sizeable following among the Satnamis, something that has prevented their straying wholesale to the BSP. The Dalit outfit could affect about 15 seats in the belt.

Raman doesn't face any charges of corruption but he has done little to acquire the image of an efficient administrator. Local issues count. National concerns do not matter enough in largely tribal-rural Chhattisgarh. Jogi, a fierce critic of the Salwa Judum campaign backed

by the Government against the Naxals in the districts of south Bastar, has promised to wind it up if the Congress comes to power. Raman says this is a successful programme.

This election is devoid of any major issue or wave and it has eventually boiled down to the personalities—Raman vs Jogi at the state level, and individual candidates against each other at the constituency level. A victory in Chhattisgarh would be an outcome of who micro-manages the polls better. ■









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